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Milt Fillius

Milton F. Fillius Jr. was born in Rochester, NY on November 17, 1922. As a youth he developed a love for swing music and played drums in a number of bands with his high school friends. Milt is a 1944 graduate of Hamilton College and a member of the "crazy mixed up years," comprised of the Hamilton men who served their country during World War II. Milt achieved great success in the world of business and took an active role in numerous civic and charitable organizations. Throughout his life he has been an ardent fan and patron of jazz and it was his vision that made the Fillius Jazz Archive a reality.

Milt was interviewed in Clinton, New York, on May 18, 2000, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: It's a special day because we're filming at Hamilton College for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and I'm very, very pleased to have Milt Fillius with me today who is the driving force behind this effort.

MF: Thank you.

MR: So thanks for coming.

MF: My pleasure. We had a time doing it.

MR: Right. I've known you for about, over five years now, but there's a lot of holes in what I know about you. And you may prefer it that way.

MF: Well there are some holes that will remain holes.

MR: Okay. So we'll just fill in a few blanks if you don't mind, and then we'll get to talk about the archive. I know you come from Rochester.

MF: Right.

MR: And when you were in your teens that was the swing era starting.

MF: Yes.

MR: Can you tell me when that first grabbed your attention? That music?

MF: 1935.

MR: Why specifically that year?

MF: Well I was 13. And when I was 12 years of age my father said son, you are now going to earn your own way. You're going to earn your keep and I'll provide a roof over your head and food but you'll earn your clothing, your spending money and so on, which he deemed to be a way to build character. So I started out and I had paper routes and an old thing called "Radio Mirror" magazine routes and I worked in a drug store and a grocery store. And I had a very busy time. Then I found the drums. And I started playing the drums and I took lessons from the guy who was the head percussionist with the Rochester

out and for the rest of my time in high school we played a lot, made a lot — for those days — made a lot of money. You know you get five or ten bucks for a night and you thought oh geez I'm on top of the world. But I used all that money to buy records. And I just — there's a record store in Rochester — Lovett's I think is the name of it — and I drove them crazy. I spent every Saturday in the booths in there playing stuff and buying stuff. And I fell in love with Benny Goodman and Artie Shaw, the Dorseys, the whole bit. And I had a collection of records that was pretty damn good, which I retained until the war. And then when I went off to war my father got them and fortunately he taped all the 78s for me, and then we threw them away. But that's how I got started.

MR: Were your parents musical?

MF: No. My father became so. He caught the bug. He caught the bug really during the war when he was playing my stuff he thought that's not bad you know. And I was really hooked on it. I'll tell you one story that remains bright in my mind. A friend of mine and I were in Washington, DC at my grandmother's house and I think it was '35 or '6, when the Spanish Civil War was going on, whenever the hell that was. And the Benny Goodman band was to play at the Raleigh Hotel in downtown Washington. And we decided we had to see that somehow. So we went down to the hotel in the daytime and welcomed the band when they came in. And Harry James went off in a side exit to smoke a cigarette. So we went out and talked to him and said, "Geez I sure would like to see that band. He said, "Well," he says, "I'll tell you what, meet me here at intermission and I'll take you in." So we did. We came down that night at intermission. James took us in, and he set me up right next to Krupa on the bandstand, who was my idol. And I had a wonderful time. And then Benny came in and gave me the ray you know. So we stayed a couple of sets and then we left. But that was the highlight of my youth.

MR: That's amazing. It's so interesting, because I think back when I was that age, and I was a bit older, but the Beatles came in, and there was all that flak about them and that hype, and the girls loved them. And now I look at my own kids, and they have their own little stars. But the swing guys were your stars.

MF: That's right.

MR: That was the popular music of the day.

MF: Still are. If you note the people that we've brought up here to jazz concerts are primarily veterans of the swing age. That's why they're all in their 70s and so on and they're not going to be around long. But fortunately you have them on tape so.

MR: Right. I've asked a number of the musicians what is swing.

MF: Yeah.

MR: Do you have an idea on how to define that?

MR: Yeah. It has a beat. There's no other beat like it. And there are people who played in the swing era who weren't swingers, but the minute I hear it I know it. The beat. It's a heavy four/four beat, and — it's heavy but it's light at the same time. It's totally unlike the rock & roll stuff with the drummer banging away. I mean that doesn't take any talent to do that. But you see if a fellow like Butch, Butch Miles. He's the epitome of a good swing drummer. Now all you have to do is listen to him make rhythm and that's it. And everybody reacts to it, the swing people.

MR: Did you learn any of that swing drumming from your teacher at Eastman?

MF: Oh no, no, just the rudiments.

MR: Right. So after that it was pretty much listening and emulating?

MF: Yeah. Well I used to do "Sing Sing Sing" with my eyes closed. In fact, later on in life when I was running a shipyard in San Diego, I had a big house and one room was a music room and I had in it huge speakers and my drumset. And I would come home from work tense and ready to kill somebody you know, and I'd turn on a record and play it as loud as I could and I'd go in and beat the drums and play with it. And that was the way I relieved tension in those days. But it's very distinctive. It's a rhythm and it's catchy. It lilts. And the minute you put something on I can tell whether it's swing music or not. But that rhythm is still — well when you hear all the concerts we've got, they've all been swing based. I don't' know that that's the right word for it or the right term, but that's where it started.

MR: I think it's a good term. What was the repertoire that your particular dance band would play?

MF: Oh gee. "Blue Moon," "Red Sails in the Sunset," we did a novelty thing called "Old Man Mose" and I was the singer.

MR: Is that right?

MF: Oh yeah. And we did "White Heat," Jimmy Lunceford's "White Heat." We just bought standard, off the shelf arrangements. "Harbor Lights," all the tunes of the times. The kids loved to dance to them.

MR: So you played like high school dances?

MF: Oh yeah. My father had laid down the rule that I could not go anyplace they served booze. And I pretty much obeyed that until one night I was at a place called the Dutch Mill in Rochester, which is near where my wife used to live and where I used to live. And they served beer. And we were in the bandstand playing away and I looked up and there my mother and father are dancing. So I caught hell for it. But I actually never had a drink. I never touched it until I came here to the college. All the way through high school and all the way through those days, I didn't drink although I played in many places, really,

where they served drinks. They weren't heavy hitters like they have now but there were places where they served beer. And most people don't get too drunk on beer.

MR: Did you have aspirations to do music full time?

MF: No. I do now but I didn't. I look at the fellas that I admire so, and I think God what I wouldn't give to have that talent. Because it's God given, the good ones. They don't learn it, you can't learn it. You either got it or you don't got it. And I look at like Kenny Davern who is coming up here today, his talent on clarinet is unmatched. And where did it come from? He didn't do it learning scales. I don't know whether he got it from Pee Wee Russell or where, but he's a very instinctive player. And Bob Wilber who was here before — I mean all of them. They have tremendous talent. Look at Wilber. He writes and he directs and he plays and he arranges and he's got a hell of a talent. He didn't learn that by rote.

MR: All right. We're going to take a pause here for a moment. Apparently we have a little—

MF: Yeah, my voice is too loud I'm afraid. I'm sorry.

MR: It's so deep tuned.

MF: And that's why there's never a question about who's on the telephone.

TH: People listen when you talk.

MR: Do you remember — I remember this distinctly — the first time I ever talked to you when this whole thing came up, I had the meeting with Mary Kopcza and the whole thing, and then I called you and I said, "Mr. Fillius? This is Monk Rowe and I'm calling from Hamilton College." And you said, "I've heard of it." I'll never forget that. I'll also never forget the first time I called Joe and that voice over the phone, it was so rich and low that it was really —

MF: He was an amazing character.

MR: Well we'll talk about him too.

MF: People never knew that he was a great philosopher. I mean it's totally aside from his talent. He really —

MR: Is that good? Okay. I'm just going to pick up from where we were.
It seems like a pretty mature attitude on your part at that time to know that maybe you couldn't make a living as a musician?

MF: Monk, I don't know that I really ever thought about it to tell you the truth. In those days I went off to college and in college here I didn't play. We had occasional visits from Eddie Condon, Ernie Anderson, Joe's brother, was his manager, and he came up here several times and other big bands and I saw that. But I was kind of out of it except for playing records and so on. And I really didn't get active again with respect to dealing with the musicians and the music itself until much later in life. I always remained interested and I

my college was interrupted by the war. Then I thought well why plan? I went in the submarine service and one out of four of us didn't come back. And I thought well live it up, man. And when I did come out I had enough credits piled up so I went to law school. And I got a law degree and went to California and took the bar exam and never practiced law. But at that point it was pretty late to be thinking about music, plus the fact that as you well know, if you don't stay with it you lose it. A drummer especially, if his wrists aren't working all the time he doesn't have it. And while I used to sit in once in a while just for laughs with some guys, I just didn't have the knack anymore.

MR: What brought you to Hamilton? What about this place appealed to you?

MF: Well when I was a senior in high school I narrowed down the places of opportunity to eight or nine and I sent for their material. And I picked three of them. My father sent me to each of them for a weekend. And the three were Oberlin, Middlebury and here. And I just came here, I felt wonderful, and we had some friends of my father's who made me feel at home and so on and one guy over in the Theta Delta house was a buddy. So it felt natural that this is where I'd most like to be so I just came. I wasn't looking for anything special, just a liberal arts education, but in those days a college education was a college education. You took what you could get. And I'll say this for the record that — nobody would ever believe it — but the cost of coming to Hamilton College was $400 a semester. I ran across one of the old bills not too long ago. And my dad, this was of course in the middle of the depression, my dad paid $400 to send me to school. So think about that as you pay your daughter's bills.

MR: I'll try to keep it in mind.

MF: I just saw the minutes of the last trustee's meeting, God it's $32,000 to come to this school. Incredible.

MR: Did the fact that it was a men's school have an effect on your decision one way or the other?

MF: I think it did but I didn't realize it at the time. And I'm glad it was. It was a great experience.

MR: And you were in a frat?

MF: Yeah. Everybody was. In those days fraternities were very meaningful here. Eighty percent of the population was in a fraternity house. They had to have them for living, they didn't have the dorms that they have now. And they were good institutions. They were well mannered, and each freshman would have a senior who looked after him. And for example I learned how to drink. Politely. We dressed for dinner every night. And we learned manners. And we were really well groomed. We had kids coming to this campus straight off the farm. I had a roommate like that. And boy he's a real gentleman now. And

MR: Yeah. So it was an education in more ways than one.

MF: Oh yeah. It wasn't like the houses before — when I came back and looked at them I was disgusted. My house was so bad I wouldn't even go near it. It was a mess. And beer cans all over the place. And what had happened was that the sophomores were living in the house because now there were girls in the dorms and the seniors and juniors wanted to be where the girls are. So there's nobody to keep things under control in those houses. And they all went to hell, every one of them. So now we're in better shape now. Actually the move the trustees made was a very good one I think. Very sound. Fraternities still exist, but they don't have the houses.

MR: I have a quote here from you, from a number of years ago, and you said that the class of 1944 was a rare breed, one of the best Hamilton has ever had.

MF: That's right.

MR: What was the reason for that?

MF: I don't know. We had a librarian named Pilkington who wrote a book when he left about the college, and it was said that the class of 1944 was terrible and never should have been admitted. And I think his reason was maybe the same reason — that was the first class that did not require a basic background of study of Latin or Greek. It was the first time that we could get in with a romance language. I got in for example with French or German, one of the two. And Latin and Greek had been the requirement ever since. And if you base your education on that it's a little different than — more stilted I think than other forms of education. I think the war had a lot to do with it because everybody I know who went to that war and came back in one piece is a better man for it. And we had some guys who might otherwise not have been as successful. I don't think I would have been if I'd just gone through college and had not gone to law school and gone to California and all the rest of it. I certainly wouldn't have been. And the result is that that class has turned out some pretty good people that have been very good to this college.

MR: Those years were called the "crazy mixed up years?"

MF: Yeah, right.

MR: I want to make sure I get that right, where a lot of the fellas came back and graduated a couple of years later than they might have.

MF: We all did. But a lot of us didn't. A lot of my class never did graduate. They went elsewhere, but they still come back to our reunions and they consider this their home. I don't know what the percentages are but there are a lot of them. And many people went to graduate school and I could have done that. When I came back from the war I was 12 hours short of a degree. I elected to come back in the summer and pick up those 12 hours before I went to law school in the fall. But I could have not done that, I could have just

gone to law school. But with the twelve hours I was able to graduate, which I did in '47 instead of '44.

MR: What made you pursue the submarine school?

MF: Well I don't know. I was in the midshipman's school at Columbia. And there were I think 1,200 of us. And they put up lists, what did you want to do. And I got to thinking about the fact that most all the guys who were basically civilians like me got to do landing craft. And I thought that was a terrible way to end your life. And I wasn't a flyer, but submarine service offered a lot of things. It offered first of all 50 percent increase in pay. It offered wonderful food, excellent food, and a pretty good life. And it was distinctive. You were one of five or six thousand of us in the war and that's it. And we are a pretty distinctive breed really. So I volunteered for it. And they then sent a team around of three people: a commanding officer, an engineering officer and a mustang, that is a guy who came up from the ranks and who is rough and tough and so on. And they interviewed each of us. And I didn't know the answers to any of the questions. I was an English literature major, and the engineering guy said, "What's the difference between AC and DC current?" I said, "Dammed if I know." And I was just honest about it. And I figured well that's gone. Well as it turned out there were five of us that they picked. Four engineers and me, which obviously was a mistake. Somebody got the wrong number. It couldn't have been me. So I went to submarine school. And the first thing they do, they spent two weeks with a nut house trying to figure out whether you can stand the pressure, and whether you get along with people well, and schizophrenia and all that stuff. And if you pass that you're home free. You have to graduate from the school. They won't let you flunk. I was the only one to pass out of the five of us. The four engineers went out to the amphibious fleet. So there I was. And I was in submarines and submarine school. I had a wonderful time.

MR: I guess you don't suffer from claustrophobia.

MF: Oh no. Well looking back it was pretty tough but when you're young and there's a war on, a war that everybody wants to win, that was pretty nifty. I enjoyed every minute of it.

MR: And you eventually went overseas in Southeast Asia?

MF: Oh yeah. We won't get into that. The exploits in Australia and so on. That's not something we'll talk about.

MR: No? Not even in part two of our interview?

MF: No, but it was a wonderful experience, wonderful people. I never met a single person I didn't like in the service, in the submarine service. It was a great experience.

MR: Was there ever a time when you didn't think you were going to come back from that?

MF: Yeah. That wasn't such a good experience. That was a time that we call brownie shorts.

MR: That's hard, and as you said, you can't help but become a stronger, better person for going through that.

MF: That's right. Well just going through boot camp, today you don't have to go to war. If you can handle boot camp, say a Marine boot camp, you're a better man, and you're a better citizen too.

MR: Do you think that a draft should still exist today?

MF: Yeah, I do. I think it's a mistake to lower the standards of the people in the service. I would make it an easy draft, I'd say take you in for a year, year and a half and then you'd go about your business as I guess the Swiss do that, and some other people. I wouldn't draft them for four or five years and so on, but I think number one, I think everybody should do it. I think it's worthwhile. I think it's a good experience and it's good for you to do that. But the things they're doing now trouble me. They can't fill — they're sixty thousand people short. But the interesting thing is that the only service that is full is the Marines, and they're the toughies. You go in there, you get hell. I mean that's the worst. But they have every billet filled by volunteers. So I don't know what that tells you but—

MR: People like a challenge.

MF: Yeah.

MR: Were you fellas able to follow any of the music scene that was happening in the states while you were overseas?

MF: Oh sure. And we got — I'll never forget — we got a lot of the electrical transcriptions that the guys did, and boy there's some wonderful jazz on those things. And it's too bad they ended up the way they did but we'd get those, I used to play those all the time.

MR: Were those the V-discs, or was that something different?

MF: No, these were big, well they were as big as LPs really. And they were jazz — well you've heard Benny Carter and others talk about how they got a bum deal out of it but there's still a lot of them that are under wraps that you can't get. But they'd ship those over and lots of them. And we had movies on the submarines. I saw "Destination Tokyo" at least five hundred times.

MR: Did you guys chuckle sometimes at the way the war was portrayed in films?

MF: Oh yes. Yes. We'd watch — that movie in particular was the popular war submarine movie of the time. And we'd set it up in the Forward Torpedo Room, the guys would just sit around and with a little projector you know. And they knew every line. They'd go through it, every single line, the guys would know. And laugh. It was so much bull you know. But they got a kick out of it.

MR: It was a — I'm not sure special is the right word — but it certainly was a significant historical time in this country.

MR: And when you look back on it, I just had seen a promotional film that Jimmy Stewart had done, trying to get pilots. And it worked amazingly well I guess.

MF: Yeah.

MR: People responded to that kind of thing.

MF: Yeah. But they made a lot of them. And we never lost. We never lost.

MR: Let me talk about the music just for a minute. At that time did you or any of your musical — the fans of the music — make a distinction between the white bands and the black bands?

MF: No. And to be honest with you, when Goodman took on Teddy Wilson and Lionel Hampton I didn't think that was such a big deal. And the Jimmy Lunceford band, God, that really knocked me over. That was a tremendous band, jeez. And showmen.

MR: I'm sorry, who?

MF: Jimmy Lunceford.

MR: Oh. Showmen. Yes.

MF: A showmen. All the shows they put on when they play you know. And well we know some of the veterans of that band, don't we?

MR: Yeah.

MF: No — Duke Ellington, Count Basie, Benny Goodman, Artie Shaw. I didn't make — there was no distinction really. And I don't think the people in my group gave any real thought to the fact that a white band would take on a black player or vice versa. Much more likely than a black band taking on a white player by the way, but I didn't sense any of what I feel now out there, that there's some strife brewing that some people — who shall remain unnamed — say that there are no whites who know how to play jazz. Well that's just plain hooey.

MR: It's distressing that —

MF: It is distressing.

MR: That it's not getting better.

MF: Yeah. Well you know it just was never a thing when I was young. I mean black guys and white guys enjoyed music together, they played together. I remember spending an evening with the Ellington band back stage, and Johnny Hodges trying to put the make on my friend's wife, and you know, it was normal. And Joe Williams way back when. Joe and I were friends for years, and we never had a question of — he'd call me his white brother and I'd call him my black brother, but we never had a racial problem. And I don't think, well he and his wife did but that's another thing.

MR: So you came back from the service and went to law school.

MF: I went here, and then to law school, and then right to California.

MR: Did the business that you got into, was it serendipitous somehow? How did that actually happen?

MF: Well I went to California. I studied the summer in June of '49. I studied for the bar, took the bar in November, October, and went looking for a job. And all the law firms said yeah we love you, you look great, you went to a good school, and when you pass the bar come on back. Well I had a wife and a child and a pregnant wife at that. And I needed some dough. So I heard of a guy, a big guy in town who needed an administrative assistant with legal training, so I thought well I'll try that. So I went to see him and I got the job and I went to work for this fella, who owned a bank and a bunch of other stuff in town. And I worked for him for a year or so and then one of the things he owned was a little shipyard. And somebody was stealing from the shipyard, so he called me and asked me would I go down to the shipyard and sign on as assistant treasurer and see if I could find out who it was. I said okay, but remember I don't want to stay there, I want to come back to the bank. I want to be uptown. Because I was still thinking I was going to practice. And I was right in the middle of everybody who was anybody in town. I had every connection there could possibly be in this little town. Anyway I went down as assistant treasurer and the first day I discovered that the crook was the treasurer.

MR: The first day you discovered that?

MF: The first day, yeah. So I reported that, and then I had to stay on as treasurer you see. And I stayed for five or six months I guess, and I got very upset because the company wasn't doing anything and the management stunk and there was no future, you know, nothing. So I quit. And I resigned, and that night he came out to my house and talked me into coming back to run the shipyard. So I did. And I had a hell of a time.

MR: That's an amazing leap for a young man.

MF: Yeah, my objective incidentally was to make that as good a shipyard as could be, but to build a submarine. That was my objective. Never made it.

MR: Wow. Ship building is a whole amazing field.

MF: We could spend hours on that.

MR: Okay.

MF: Let's not.

MR: But you went from there to a conglomerate that had a whole bunch of different things going on.

MF: That's right.

MR: Did you move from those things because you needed a new challenge?

MF: Well the shipyard we built into a big thing. It's now the biggest shipyard on the west coast. And it was the biggest employer in San Diego at the time I left. We sold it to

that big operation. So I told my good friend Edgar Kaiser I was going to leave, and did. And I went back with the guy who owned the shipyard in the first place, who now had a bank and a cannery and a bunch of tuna boats and the Yellow Cab Company in L.A. and San Francisco and a bus line in Kansas City. So I became the Executive Vice President of that company and ran all those businesses. And I was doing all right I guess. Then I discovered that there was some phony financing going on. I was on the board incidentally of this company. And I discovered that my boss the banker was playing games. And for example I had several million dollars worth of tuna sitting in the warehouse, canned tuna, and found it was hocked to three separate banks. So I said we can't do that, you can't do that. He said oh yes I can. I said well okay. But not with me you can't. So I left. It was just that I didn't want to be part of it. Several years later it collapsed. And too bad. Because he was a nice guy. But he just didn't understand that the law was made for him. And he and Dick Nixon were friends and you know, they thought alike.

MR: Well I can tell from your record collection that you must have been collecting all those years.

MF: Yeah, somewhat. But mostly after the law school and so on, that's when I really picked up on it. Because while I was in the Navy and here I didn't have any time to do it. But I did then, yes.

MR: What were the years when you first started to meet these musicians? Because I've been really amazed over the years how many of them you've gotten to know and how did that come about, from your travel?

MF: Jazz parties. I would say in the early 60s it started. I started out I went to — well I knew some people just from rolling around town in San Diego. But I really met them at Dick Gibson's parties. And I went to 25 of those straight. And I went for the same reason that I wanted to do the archive, I knew that the following year there would be some I wouldn't see again. And that was true every year. And anyway I went to those parties and Dick and I became very friendly and I went to some of his private parties and so on and I got to know a lot of these people. And some of them I became very friendly with and some of them are just nodding acquaintances. I have found them as a group to be tremendous friends, very loyal. My definition of a friend is a guy you can call at 3 A.M. and say I'm in jail come get me out. And they all would, the ones that I know. So they've been almost my best friends all these years. A lot of them.

MR: You got to travel to New York a number of times over the years.

MF: Oh yes.

MR: And hit those clubs?

MF: Well I'm a veteran of the Metropole. In 1958, 7 or 8, is when we started pushing the

New York, U.S. Lines, Moore McCormick and American Export. And I had to work the Maritime Commission in Washington as well. So I was on a schedule to take me to the east coast two and three times a week. When I was in New York what was involved was going down in the morning, down to where all the marine activity is, calling on somebody, having a drunken lunch with them, and then going back to the hotel to take a nap, and then spend the evening at the place, at the Metropole there. I'll never forget, there was a bartender there named Blackie who was my buddy. And my secretary back in San Diego knew that if she wanted me, that's where I'd be. And everybody was there, in those days that's the only place — you know Ryan's and all those places were gone. This was the only place that jazz really existed. And hell they'd have the Hampton band and the Ellington band and the Basie band, and oh they got Red Allen, Higginbotham, oh they were all there — Coleman Hawkins, Coleman Hawkins and Roy Eldridge had a group there and they played every night. And there was a big band — you ever been there, the Metropole?

MR: No.

MF: Well there's a big bandstand behind the bar. And standing room, and then booths along the side. And they'd just change every half hour. And everybody's having a good time. Red Allen was there greeting everybody at the door when they came in, and it was a wonderful time. Really, if you didn't like the music you had to like it there. I never realized until later how great it was. I never realized. I thought all these names, you know, and some I didn't really know well, and later as I collected records I said Jesus, I know this guy. And they just put on a terrific show. Buster Bailey. Remember Buster Bailey?

MR: Sure.

MF: And he was a friend, Dizzy was there.

MR: Did they charge to get into this place?

MF: No.

MR: That's amazing. How did they pay the musicians?

MF: You'd go in and buy a beer. I'm not sure. They had a second story. They may have had an entrance fee because they put the bands up there. It may have cost you fifty cents or a dollar to get in. But you'd go there, and I'd just sit there and drink three or four bottles of beer in the night. Terrific. Marvelous. And as I say you stay at the bar and then as these people came off they'd swing by the bar and say hello and so on and so forth. And I'm trying to think — Cozy Cole. Cozy was there. And just everybody who was anybody in jazz played in that place. All night long. They started in the afternoon and went all night long. And you talk to any of those guys they were all there, and they all played. Well you

MR: Yes indeed.

MF: Sol was there.

MR: For a very long time.

MF: He was about the least talented fella there. Nice guy. And he was so proud of the fact that he taught Steve Allen how to play the clarinet for "The Benny Goodman Story."

MR: Right.

MF: And oh there was another clarinet player, Dixie style. Oh you'd know his name too.

MR: It wasn't that fella that ended up with Armstrong was it?

MF: No, no, no, no. But oh dear — well you've got some of his records in the collection.

MR: Well you had mentioned San Diego as a little city when you went out there.

MF: It was then.

MR: Amazing what has happened out there.

MF: We had three hundred thousand people. Now we have over a million. It was a hell of a town. And it was like no other that I know of, that some young kid like me could step in there and with a couple of lucky breaks, and hell I was head of everything over the time I was there. I was in the Y and the Boy Scouts and the civic—

MR: The Chamber of Commerce.

MF: I was president of the Chamber of Commerce for a couple of years. And all that stuff. And at one point the city fathers wanted me to run for mayor. And I told them I couldn't afford to because the twelve thousand dollars that was the stipend for the mayor was exactly the amount of my alimony. So they said we'll make it up to you. I said oh no, we don't do that. But without blowing smoke, I could been elected mayor easy. The owner of the newspaper, Jim Gottlieb took a shine to me. And the paper was never published without a picture or a quote from Fillius.

MR: Do you have any of those?

MF: Oh yes.

MR: Good.

MF: My wife threw them in a box. My father, who lived there for a number of years before he died, really got — well he was very proud of it I guess — but he just kidded the hell out of me. He says, "Every time I pick up the paper it says 'Fillius says.'"

MR: Well that happens here too.

MF: No.

MR: I think it does on occasion.

MF: In those days it was a small town and it was a wonderful place. We were trying to get things done out there now and it's just not the same thing. We had, you could get eight or ten guys together, the right eight or ten guys, and do anything. You could build a

they owned banks or this, that or the other thing. And if they wanted to do something they could. And that's how we built the City Hall, the present City Hall, and now they want to change it and the Civics Theater and all that stuff was all built because these people decided we ought to have it. No more. San Diego is a by-station now. See the banks for example have all been absorbed by Bank of America, Wells Fargo and those guys from up north. And the people who are sent down to manage those banks are just marking time waiting to go back up north so that they can continue their career. So you can't really get them interested in the kind of things we did. That's the big problem in San Diego. There's no leadership anymore. But when I was there it was just a bunch of us. And we all wanted good things for the community. So we did a lot.

MR: Let's talk about Joe for a bit.

MF: Joe who? Drown or Williams?

MR: Well let's talk about Joe Williams.

MF: Okay.

MR: When was the first time that you actually got to know him?

MF: How about the first time I saw him? I was back here on a shipbuilding expedition with my chief engineer and the two of us went to Birdland. And we had a table about so big in the front row, of the Basie band. I didn't know Joe Williams from a hill of beans. And we were sitting there talking very seriously about a problem. And all of a sudden I looked down and there were the biggest feet I've ever seen in my life. Huge feet. And I looked up and up and up and up, and here's this big, ugly, black man. And it was Joe. And he started to sing. And we thought that was pretty good. And then I started collecting his records after that. This was in the 50s, when he first sprang up with the Basie band, before he went on his own. And as you may notice from the collection we have all of Joe's records, all that we know of anyway. And I was very enamored of his talent. Still am. I believe that he never received the recognition he should have. That as a blues singer he was terrific but on a ballad he was fantastic. He's just got a beautiful voice. And a couple of his songs, a couple of his recordings, I have used to woo my wife sitting over there. So it's very dear to me. And I guess the next time I really saw him and got to know him, I was in Chicago. And it was a snowy night and I was on my way from the Blackstone Hotel to the one that has the pump room across town. Anyway, we're in a cab driving down Rush Street and there is a place called New Orleans or something like that, it's a New Orleans type name, and it had big letters, Joe Williams. I says stop the cab. And I got out and I went in. And I sat in the front row and we started talking between sets. And finally he said well come on back. So I went in the back room and sat there all night. And we talked about everything in the world. Race relations, you name it. And

MR: What was his view on race relations at that time? Anything that you can remember?

MF: He thought it was pretty stupid. He thought the whole thing was pretty stupid. He was hurt, but I think for example he and his wife had problems. She was a little, white English girl as you know. And there are people who frowned on that. They don't so much anymore, but at the time — in fact his father-in-law was very upset when he married. Then he found out that the guy that his daughter had married was a famous singer named Joe Williams. Then he became very proud and he bragged to everybody in this little British village that his daughter was married to Joe Williams. And when Joe Williams came to town he was very proud of him. So he thought the initial reaction was dumb. He was proud of black people when they were good. I think he appreciated talent wherever it was. I think he was extremely concerned about people, black people who have a thing about white people, who are prejudiced in that sense. I don't think he ever would have let race interfere with what was right. I just never found anything to object to in his attitude.

MR: Did you find the same type of feeling in the other fellas of that era that you got to know like Milt Hinton?

MF: Well I think so but I don't know him that well. Milt Hinton I'm pretty sure is broad minded about anything. But he is from an era where you don't display your feelings. And most of the black guys I know, Terry and Sweets Edison and people like that — you just never get on that subject. You know that they like you. You know that you're their friend and that there's no color bar between you. But I don't think you ever get far enough in their innermost thoughts to know what they think. Milt Hinton for example. His first memory when he was three years old he was looking out the window to see his uncle hung by the Ku Klux Klan. You know, that's got to do something to you. And I always wondered how Milt could be so broad minded and accept whatever came along with that in his head. I'd say it would have to leave a scar. But Milt and Mona have millions of white friends. I mean boy, there's nothing like it. More so than anybody I think.

MR: Yeah, they attract — people want to be near them.

MF: Yes.

MR: You know there's something about them that they make you feel good.

MF: They're nice people.

MR: The Basie band over the years was one of your favorites.

MF: Well they produced a lot of great musicians.

MR: Yeah. Did you have a particular era of that group that you liked the most?

MF: Well the one I knew the most was in the 50s and 60s with Frank Wess and Frank Foster, Marshall Royal, Joe Newman. That was the group that I guess I was most familiar with because that's when most of the recordings were made that I had. They went on and there

he was at a Gibson party. He'd had cancer and he'd been told never to play again. At the end of the party he grabbed his sax. And then he died.

MR: Well it's been a great year to live through for you, and I've said a number of times I always felt like I was born in the wrong era.

MF: Well you certainly don't have what we had.

MR: That's true.

MF: I just can't stomach most of the stuff I hear today. And I don't understand it. And I always hearken back to Louis Armstrong, the boppers and this — what the hell song is it he does — "The Whiffinpoof Song." He's got a line in "The Whiffinpoof Song" about the boppers with the hey-de-hey and stuff. But I still don't understand a lot of the people who are important in jazz some years back — Ornette Coleman. I mean God I'll never forget I was at the jazz festival in Northern California, what the hell —

MR: I think I know what you mean. Monterey.

MF: Monterey. Thank you. The Monterey Jazz Party, and I went out to go to the bathroom and when I came back in there was this terrible noise. Woody Herman's band was there, and the Ellington band was there, and a lot of great guys. And there was this terrible sound and this guy up there with a white plastic saxophone. And I thought for God's sakes, what's going on here? And that was Ornette Coleman. First time I'd heard him. And it just didn't make any sense to me. Still doesn't. But people like me are dying off. There aren't many of us left you know.

MR: Well he was innovating but what he was innovating was—

MF: It wasn't musically pleasing to me at all.

MR: Did you even notice that —

MF: And he doesn't swing by the way.

MR: Oh.

MF: See those guys don't swing.

MR: When you came back from the war did you notice, did you sense this bebop thing happening? Was it in the musical press that you can remember, like *Down Beat* and all this in the late 40s?

MF: No.

MR: Okay. I'm just trying to get a sense of —

MF: I think in the '50s yeah, but in the late '40's no. The press had to do mostly with the downfall of the big bands. And I guess Dizzy got some press. But if you look at the *Down Beat* and *Metronome* contest for the musician of the year you won't find Dizzy in those years. You will in the 50s, you'll find Dizzy and Charlie Parker and people like that. And they're good musicians, they really are, those guys. I just don't understand some of the

MR: What was your take on the reason the big bands really disappeared?

MF: Well I think probably it was television for one thing, and just a lack of interest and I don't know why really. We had all these dance halls that closed down all of a sudden. The radio, see the radio stopped. One of the big things about the big band era was the radio support. If you lived in this coast you could start about ten o'clock at night and turn on your radio and there'd be remotes from all over the world. And every band you can think of was on. And if you listened to — what the hell's his name that does the yearly thing? Chuck Cecil? You ever heard of Chuck Cecil?

MR: No.

MF: Well Chuck Cecil runs programs, the hits of '48 and '49 and so on. And he always opens by talking about these dance halls and we all know where they were. There was the Palladium in L.A. where Goodman broke through. There was Glen Island Casino over here and Frank Daly's Meadowbrook, and Boston, everyplace. There were places all over the country that were known because they were broadcast from there. And that's how these bands were made. That's how Goodman was made. Goodman was made because of the broadcasts on the Camel Caravan. And that's really what held it together. And these bands that traveled went from place to place and they had a built-in following. That all stopped. When the war came along it all stopped. Petrillo of course had his hand in it. He killed it for a while. And the people who continued and the ones who have continued to this day you can count on one finger practically. Les Brown. Welk. Welk's no longer. That's about it. They just aren't. The Basie band without Basie, and all the ghost bands of course there are now. And they're still making a living.

MR: I think the Basie band is probably the truest to — at least they have a steady personnel. Some of the other ones come in and use local guys sometimes.

MF: Well I think that's right. But I think the truest band is the Artie Shaw Band. Because Artie Shaw runs it.

MR: I was not aware of that.

MF: Oh yeah. When that band was formed Artie Shaw formed it. He picked Dick Johnson to do the clarinet. He picked the arrangements, he rehearsed them. When that band was relatively new I remember at Disneyland, Disneyland had a program in the summer when they'd put two weeks of different bands. And I was down there one night and I went to hear them. And Artie Shaw was there watching it. And he refused to ever play. He never played again. But he is very interested in seeing that band. So to me they were the truest to the arrangements that Artie Shaw used to play. They were the closest. The Dorseys and the others and the rest of them are nothing like it. But that band sounded better. They were all young kids, and sounded better than the Artie Shaw band did in the 40s, in my

you know they came back here for a dance, it was that same band. Went over in the gym, God the acoustics were so awful. I sat there and I couldn't believe it. I'd forgotten how bad they were.

MR: Right. You can come back the next day and listen to the echoes.

MF: Yeah it was terrible.

MR: Well I wanted to talk a little bit more about your faithfulness and your support of Hamilton College and I'm impressed by the group of men from your class and from others back then who have had a lifelong commitment to this college. Can you explain why?

MF: I've often wondered. The people here did a terrific job of injecting us all with some kind of fluid. We came out of here thinking Hamilton is a wonderful place, and we never changed that viewpoint. I can't understand for example my own kids, who went to other schools, which I would consider the same kind of school, small and so on, and they don't give a damn. They don't give them any money, they don't care. I just don't understand, I say why don't you ever go back? They're just not interested. They got an education and they got out. I could give you an example of the difference I think. When the war ended, this college took Carnegie Dorm and converted it to apartments for veterans with wives. So each one of the three man apartments was equipped with a dish cupboard and a refrigerator and a stove and so on. And they practically gave those to us when we came back. I lived in one the summer I was here. They put a laundry under Buttrick, and we all moved in. There was 24 couples over there in that building, and we had a hell of a time. And then they built the Village, which has now been removed, back of the Alpha Delta house. So they had a concern for us okay? I left there and I went one day out to Michigan. I went to Ann Arbor, registered for the law school and said now where do I live? Huh? And I had a hell of a time. In the middle of the winter we moved three times in that damn town, and ended up in a scummy place where I spent the rest of the three years. But the point was nobody cared. Nobody cared. And you were a number. My classes were as big as the whole college here. And I must say I did well in school. I became very friendly with the professors, I was a member of the honor society that threw all the drunken parties and stuff, so I knew them better than most, but I still have no regard for that school at all. I've never been back. I've never given them any money and I'm just not interested. So there's a difference. It's an attitude I think, towards the students. I mean here, my freshman year every second Saturday my roommate and I would go to Utica and have a spaghetti dinner with two professors, and just talk and come back. It's a totally different attitude. Totally different experience. And as a result of that experience I insisted that my kids at least start off in a small liberal arts college and

down to Ithaca and toured Cornell. My God. You can't even move. You can't park your car, you can't do anything. And I thought what a difference, what a difference. I think it's the type of college, and I'd be surprised if it isn't duplicated in schools like Williams and Amherst and so on. I think it's the attitude and the life you lead with the school, the relationship between you and the school. The fact that, Gene Tobin has a thing over here every week for the kids to come talk to him. I mean that doesn't exist in other schools. I think that's what makes a difference. And I don't think it's our class alone. We were very high on the list of graduate donors to our alumni fund, nationally. We're in the first ten I think. And we have a good — that's what makes this college is the alumni.

MR: Absolutely.

MF: That's the whole ball game. And the people who run it are smart enough to know that so they cater to the alumni. And that's the difference. Let's hope it will always be thus.

MR: I hope so. It seems to be continuing, if you attend reunion weekend you get that feeling.

MF: Well I think that they've done such a wonderful job — Joe Anderson, who is no longer here, caused a lot of problems but he did a lot of great things too. I think the birth of the Gold Group was just a genius idea. And that's been copied now by a lot of colleges that duplicated it. But that was his idea originally and it has helped so much to bring new alumni into the fold here. And the senior gift every year. The people care about the college. That's the difference.

MR: Well you have a beautiful building named after you and I think the most lasting thing of course is going to be this jazz archive. And I'd love to just actually hear again how this idea came to your head.

MF: Well it started with the Gibson parties in Colorado Springs and later in Denver, when I realized that every year some people did not appear again, they were gone. And they used to pay tribute to them. And I though jeez, there they've gone, and there's nothing. There's really nothing left behind. And then — I forget when it was — but it was Joe Williams and Milt Hinton were sitting down at the Alexander Hamilton Inn across the table. Joe was on one side and I was on the other and they started talking. And they went on with these anecdotes and so on. I said to Joe jeez, we ought to be taping that. Well I had previous to that tried like hell to get Dick Gibson to do something. I said we have to do something to preserve jazz. We have to. And he had a couple of ideas. I said okay, I'll fund it. So I got in $50,000 I think it was, for matching, to match, and then we'd go ahead. We were going to do some things — not like the archives but sort of like it. And he just never got off his duff. Dick Gibson did a lot for jazz but basically he was a bum. And he just never did anything. And so we canceled that. And I've been querying people, what can we do preserve this? And Dave Berger, you know David Berger. David Berger

and he said I have an idea I want to do Milt's life, and all his old friends and so on. And he said I'm going to apply to the National —

MR: Endowment for the Arts.

MF: Endowment for the Arts, for the money but I may come short. Can you help me. I said sure. I said how much you talking about? He said well probably $50,000. I said yeah I can do that. So a year passed. Dizzy Gillespie died. That triggered it. So I called and said where the hell is the thing? I said here Dizzy's gone and that's one of the key guys you know, Milt and Dizzy were friends. And he said well they wouldn't fund it. And I said well why didn't you tell me? I said maybe I can. So he came up with a number, I don't know, 250, 300, something like that, and applied to the foundation, and I engineered a grant. We had a problem in that we had to give the grant to an IRS-cleared institution. And the only one he had was Temple University. And he said I don't trust those people. He taught there. He says I don't trust those people. I said well maybe I know a place where we can put the money and they'll dish it out as you need it. So I took the thing and Gene Tobin was in, and incidentally, in between was this conversation with Milt and Joe. That's what really got me triggered with the thing. And I gave Gene the grant request and had him read it on the red eye coming back here, and he thought it was great for historic purposes. Because Gene's been wonderful throughout this. And so he called and I said okay, I got a hold of Berger and I said Hamilton College will do it. We'll put the money in trust at Hamilton College and as you need it you bill them and withdraw. So we started that. And then we tried to make an arrangement with Berger and it turned out that he was after a lot of dough and it just wasn't the right thing. And then we said well let's have Hamilton do it. We got the money. Well they had returned the money but I got it back again. And Joe Anderson and another alumnus rigged up a deal to do it, it didn't make any sense. So we canceled that and then —

MR: Mary Kopcza?

MF: Yeah, we were right at a break with the head of the thing, Joe was gone, and Dick had just come in and Dick came to see me in San Diego. And I explained to him this thing. And I said God it's dead. I'm looking for another school to put it where it will get done. He said well let me try it. So he came back and that's how Mary got into it. And you know the story from then, it went like gangbusters. And I was fortunate enough to convince you guys that you should go to jazz parties. Because Joe was going to go to everybody's house you know. It never would have worked. And that way we gave Tim some fun too, so Tim could come and see the world with his many boxes. Anyway it's been very successful since then. And while we missed a few, we've certainly gotten a lot and we got some people just in time. They're gone. Joe Williams had a big hand in this,

not cooperate because they'd been taken to town so many times. So we had Joe, we had a meeting over at C&D with Joe, and I'm not sure you were there the first time. Mary and Joe and Dean I guess and me. And Joe agreed to help out. And so we got him to sign a letter that went to all the musicians saying these guys are for real, you can bank on it, don't worry. And that's what got you in. That's why they agreed to be interviewed. So we owe a great deal to Joe. But he was all for it. And he loved the college, he really loved it. And I'll tell you, Sharon Rosengarden is nuts about this place too incidentally. But I think we've made a lot of friends in the jazz world for the college.

MR: I know we have.

MF: Yeah.

MR: We have a good reputation out there.

MF: And they talk about it. They talk about it in public.

MR: Well it was a great comfort for me to be able to drop Joe's name, when I would call these fellas, that I'm calling for Joe at Hamilton College.

MF: Yeah, right.

MR: We have a saying in my house, we call it "pre-Milt."

MF: Well you know that I think you have the best job in the world.

MR: Yes I do. But we can't go there first because that's how I'm going to end this.

MF: I see. Okay.

MR: But if you had to pick out three or four recordings that you would have on that proverbial desert island with you, the only thing that you had to listen to, can you think of a couple of things that for you really personify what the music was about? I know you've had so many, I've been moving your records around.

MF: "Swingtime in the Rockies," Benny Goodman. I'd take several Basie tunes. There's so many of them I can't think really. I think the Hefti stuff is very good. I'd take Joe Williams' "Our Love is Here to Stay." I'd take "Four Brothers," from Woody Herman. I won a big bet with that one day by the way.

MR: Yeah?

MF: Yeah we hired a new agency, an ad agency, and we got to talking about jazz, and I said I know a lot of jazz guys and so on and so forth. The guy says well I'll put you to the test. So he brought in the record the "Four Brothers." And they set it up in the room next door a couple of weeks later. And he brought me in and said, "Now what is this?" I says, "That's the 'Four Brothers,'" and then I named the four sax players. He died. He died. Well that's a sterling tune. That's really good. Ellington — I'd take a medley of all his stuff which he always does on his concerts, and I'd take the "Diminuendo and Crescendo in Blue" for the tremendous sax part, that's Paul Gonsalves. Incidentally I saw them

was stoned. Either drunk or out on dope or something, and he came back and he sat there at the stand, just out of it. Everybody's playing the set, and they started the "Diminuendo and Crescendo in Blue" and they got to the sax solo, all of a sudden he came to, he stood up and he played his brains out. Amazing.

MR: That's funny. Well let me ask you about what has to be one of the great things in this part of your life and that is Nikki.

MF: Yes.

MR: There's an interesting story about the longevity of how long you two actually knew each other.

MF: It was quite a while but we don't like to add up the years really. We first met in the eighth grade at John Marshall High School in Rochester, New York. And we have known of each other since. We came apart after college, when I went to college and she went to college. We met again in Buffalo when I went up to sign up in the Navy, enlist in the Navy, that's another story. And I ran into her and we knew each other, and we'd have gotten married then but she didn't return my phone call. Anyway, so it went on and then a few years ago I was in Rochester visiting my sister, and with my old friend whom you've met, Bob Steamer who had the band with me. We were at a place and a guy came and says, "By the way, Nelma Chauncy — which is Nikki's real name — lives on my street and she's a widow and she does a lot of gardening" and so on and so forth. So on the way back I said to my friend I said I'm really curious about Nelma, I haven't seen her in years, get her address for me so I can write her a note. So I did and she did and there you go. She bewitched me. But she's the best thing that ever happened to me. She's been a wonderful — she's gotten into jazz right up to here. She has befriended and been befriended by all my jazz friends and she's just a hell of a woman. Right?

NF: You got that right.

MR: You got that right. And I enjoyed playing at your wedding.

MF: That's right. That's right.

MR: And just so that everyone knows, your theme song as you walked down the aisle was "Things Ain't What They Used to Be."

MF: That's right. Well you know I got that idea from Dick Gibson's daughter. When she was married he said I'll get any group of musicians you want to play for your wedding. So she picked six or seven of the top guys. And they played in a wedding. And I thought now that's a clever thing to do. That's where you came in see?

MR: I was in good company then.

MF: Yeah. And that's what they played when she walked down the aisle.

MR: No kidding. Well, Milt, you've made for an amazing legacy I think.

MR: And I wanted to thank you on a couple of levels. First of all for all the people that will access this wealth of material that we have here, because as you said yesterday there's nothing exactly like this that we have here. And so it's going to be something that's going to last for a long, long time.

MF: I surely hope so.

MR: So you've done a real service for that. And then I have to thank you on a personal level because as I've said, there is actually in my house, we talk about the time before I met you and the amazing influence that you've had on my life, and that I have the best job that I could ever conceive of.

MF: Well you've earned it. You've done very, very well. The only thing I can think of that's like it in my mind is the Metropole Café. That's essentially the same thing. That you're exposed to all these people and of course you've been exposed more on a personal level. I'm sure you've found that it's a rich, rich field for acquaintances. I mean they're just wonderful people.

MR: Yes. And it's so curious. I mean we have done 190 to date. And when I think back on it, the unpleasant experiences I've had with these musicians, are on one hand. And that is really saying something.

MF: Well the people we've dealt with have a talent. They've all got a God-given talent, and that makes them different. I look at guys like Haggart and Ralph Sutton and guys like that who were drunks when they were young. They more than drank their share. But the guys who made it got smart and got off that stuff, and are the ones who have lasted, the ones that we're dealing with have all wised up from that. They've had that experience. And they make wonderful friends, they really do. And I'm very attached to a lot of them. And so is Nikki. Nikki and Sharon Rosengarden are like sisters. They call each other sisters. But I think, I know that you've done a great job and I'm damned if I'm not going to be sure that you stay on here. Because that's the key really. Because the musicians all know you now. You're Hamilton College. I'm not. It's amazing.

MR: Well I could argue about that.

MF: No, no, really, no. I go to some place and say something about Hamilton and they'll look at me and say, "Isn't that where Monk Rowe is?" I say, "Yeah, that's where Monk Rowe is." Or, "Isn't that Monk's College?" No that's right and that's fine because you're the queen bee around which all this operates. My desire, as of yesterday too, is to try to get this thing on a basis where you're safe and secure and the thing is okay to go on. Well for the public, I won't say any more about it but you know what I mean.

MR: Right. Well I just am humbled to have a part in such an operation and I love it when I see how jazz is spread all over the world, it's like an international thing now.

MR: Something that this country can be very proud of. And I think it has become recognized as an art form. I wish the dance halls still existed in a sense, so that it could exist in that world also.

MF: Well you know the swing dancing is back. I wondered if that wouldn't give birth to something, and it has a little bit but not very much.

MR: Well I'm going to give you the opportunity to have the last word here. Do you have any last words that you'd like to put on tape here?

MF: No, it's been a wonderful experience, a wonderful opportunity to be able to do this. And I'm everlastingly grateful to you and to the powers that be at this college to make it happen, because I don't think it would have happened otherwise. And we did something that really needs to be done. And if we can hold it together it's going to be very valuable someday. And I feel very good about it because it's something that's bothered me for a long time. Plus the fact that you've got my records so you can play them, they relate to most of those people. So I wish you well.

MR: Well I wish you well too and I will say of all the people I've met in this project, no one has been more interesting than you.

MF: I don't know whether that's a compliment or not. I'll accept it as such.

MR: All right.

MF: It's a humbling compliment.

MR: Thank you very much.